

## #DATA4COVID19

AFRICA CHALLENGE

From now through February 5, 2021, l'Agence française de développement (AFD), together with [Expertise France](#) and [The GovLab](#), is soliciting innovative proposals (re)using data in a collaborative and responsible way to provide actionable intelligence for decision-makers and people to respond to COVID-19 and future pandemic challenges across Africa.

[APPLY HERE](#)

## WHY? THE NEED FOR ACTIONABLE INSIGHTS

The ongoing COVID-19 pandemic is a human tragedy, impacting people around the world. The social and economic costs are huge, and they are contributing to a global slowdown affecting every country and community. The African continent, like much of the world, has been badly affected. Besides contributing to the loss of over [50,00 people](#), the pandemic is expected to:

- Result in a fall of about [1.4% in GDP](#) in Africa
- Move Sub-Saharan Africa into a recession in 2020 for the first time in 15 years, costing the region between [\\$37 billion and \\$79 billion in output losses](#) according to the World Bank.

- Expose an [additional 9.1% of the population](#) in Sub-Saharan Africa to extreme poverty, according to the International Growth Centre.
- Threaten nearly [20 million jobs in Africa](#), both in formal and informal sectors.
- Leave over [250 million children](#) out of school across Africa.
- Render [3.6 percent](#) of the population of Sub-Saharan Africa, including 3.9 million children under the age of 5, severely food deprived.
- Contribute to a [US \\$3.7 billion decline](#) in public and private health expenditures by the end of 2020.

These are among the facts known. Yet, policymakers need much more detailed analysis and actionable insights to guide their decisions, support actions of huge significance, and monitor their impact.

The prevalence of alternative data, even in traditionally data-sparse countries, and advances in data science provide a unique opportunity to experiment with new [data collaboratives](#) that bridge data sets, partners and expertise, and stakeholders to generate actionable intelligence and help decision-makers and people navigate this unprecedented crisis.

## WHAT ARE WE LOOKING FOR?

AFD, together with [Expertise France](#) and [The GovLab](#), is seeking ideas and proposals that (re)use data to provide actionable insight along the following [domains](#):

### PUBLIC HEALTH

- Tracking Disease Spread
- Developing Disease Treatment
- Identifying the Availability of Supplies
- Monitoring Adherence to Non-Pharmaceutical Interventions

### ECONOMIC

- Supporting Post-Pandemic Re-openings and Recovery
- Alleviating Pandemic-related Unemployment and Poverty
- Guaranteeing Protections for Workers
- Supporting Education and Upskilling
- Fostering Business and Government Solvency

### SOCIO-POLITICAL

- Understanding Public Perceptions and Behavior
- Protecting Human Rights and Promoting Accountability
- Addressing Misinformation

Across these domains, we seek innovative projects and data collaboratives that provide one or more of the following types of insight:



#### SITUATIONAL AWARENESS

Initiatives that leverage data to enable stakeholders across sectors to better understand COVID-19 trends and geographic distribution.



#### CAUSE-AND-EFFECT INSIGHT

Initiatives that can help stakeholders better understand the key drivers and consequences of COVID-19. They aim to establish which variables make a difference for a problem and whether further issues might be caused.



#### PREDICTION

Initiatives that leverage data to enable new predictive capabilities and allow stakeholders to assess future risks, needs, and opportunities.



#### IMPACT ASSESSMENT

Initiatives that determine which, whether, and how various interventions meet certain objectives, including the Sustainable Development Goals. They can also seek to understand impediments to certain objectives or the success of particular interventions.

## FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

### What is the geographical focus?

We seek projects targeting beneficiaries within and across Africa. In particular, we encourage actors operating in Francophone Africa to apply.

### What are the eligibility criteria?

Applicants must submit their application in English or French.

To be eligible for a grant, the applicant must:

- Be a legal person (legal entity) or a grouping of such persons (consortium) within the limit of 3 legal persons per grouping;
- The lead partner of the consortium must be established in one of the African Union countries;
- International organisations and trust funds are excluded;
- Have a bank account in the name of the entity;
- Each member of the consortium must be registered within the Trade and Companies Registry of its country;
- Be directly responsible for the preparation and implementation of the action and not act as an intermediary. Subcontracting is not allowed;
- The lead partner's average cumulative annual turnover over the last two years for which the accounts have been closed must be at least three times the grant application;
- The general liquidity ratios (current assets/current liabilities) for the last two financial years closed must be at least 1 (one). In the case of a consortium, this criterion must be met by each of its members.

The verification of eligibility is carried out on the basis of the supporting documents requested by the project. **The supporting documents requested in this phase are as follows:**

- The statutes or articles of association of each partner;
- For each member an extract of registration in the Trade and Companies Register (RCS) (less than 3 months);

- A document specifying the name and function of the legal representative of the entity;
- A document delegating power of attorney by each member of the partnership to its lead partner.

Where these documents are not provided in English or French, a translation of these documents must be attached for the analysis of the application.

If the above-mentioned supporting documents are not provided before the deadline, the application may be rejected.

**Number of applications and grants per applicant:** A legal entity may not submit more than one application, regardless of the form of its participation (as an individual legal entity or as a lead partner or member of a consortium submitting an application). If a legal entity submits more than one application, all applications in which it participates will be rejected.

**Modification of proposals:** a proposal can't be modified after February 5, 2021.

**Bidders are reminded that providing false information in the framework of the present call for proposals procedure may lead to the rejection of their bid and their exclusion from any contract and procedure financed by AFD, GovLab and Expertise France.**

## How much

The call offers recipients a contribution between €50-100K in funding. We expect between 7 -10 projects will receive awards.

## How do I apply?

Interested parties can apply [at this link](#). Applications should include a technical proposal as well as required supporting documents. For more information, please refer to Eligibility Criteria.

Applications should include:

- **A clear problem definition** and formulation of question(s) that, when answered, would provide new, actionable insight related to COVID-19 and its impact.
- **Timeline:** Given the urgency to develop insights that can help the COVID-19 response through data, we will prioritize those proposals that can produce rapid, yet rigorous, insights through existing relationships and collaborations with important data holders and other stakeholders. The Challenge is not intended to support projects that rely heavily on the generation or collection of new data.
- **Roles and Responsibilities:** The Challenge is targeted at supporting inter-organizational and inter-sectoral data collaborations to address various consequences of COVID-19 in Africa. Applications should clearly describe how different parties will contribute to the data collaborative by, for instance, providing functional access to data, conducting analysis, translating insight into action, or providing operational support.
- **Demonstration of:**
  - Access to the relevant datasets needed. We will look specifically for nontraditional databases (e.g. databases not derived solely from statistical agencies) and databases that are broadly accessible and reliable.

- Significant professional experience in the use of data analysis to answer complex questions;
  - Relationship with recognized organizations operating in Africa that are capable of and committed to act upon the insight generated, such as government or a locally based civil society group;
  - Strong and well-documented data responsibility and ethical standards;
  - Cost efficiency of the approach (as opposed to other ways to generate insight)
- A commitment that the project proposal has not been submitted for grant funding elsewhere and has not received funding from other sources.

We will not fund projects that replicate existing work, rely wholly on commonly used COVID-19 datasets (e.g. [Johns Hopkins University's COVID Resource Center](#)), produce simple visualizations or dashboards, or otherwise demonstrate no ability to influence real-world decision-makers. We welcome projects that seek to address **under-addressed aspects of the pandemic, including its social and economic components**.

## Who reviews?

A review board, composed of distinctive data scientists, domain experts, and responsible data practitioners, and facilitated by The GovLab will be established that will be used to review the different proposals and propose recommendations to AFD. If you are interested in joining the review board please contact us at [datastewards \[at\] thegovlab.org](mailto:datastewards@thegovlab.org). The composition will be announced shortly,

## How will findings be disseminated?

A dedicated website will be launched where we feature all the teams as well as other resources. The website will be used for rapid dissemination of the findings and an

existing collaboration with Cambridge University Press will enable the creation of a dedicated channel on the [Data & Policy](#) journal where the findings of the various initiatives will be peer reviewed and shared more widely.

## What is the timeline?

|                                  | DATE                 |
|----------------------------------|----------------------|
| Launch of call for applications  | December 15, 2020    |
| Informational webinar            | January 2021         |
| Deadline for applications        | February 5, 2021     |
| Application review and selection | February 18, 2021    |
| Announcement of winners          | March 2021           |
| Funded project period            | March – October 2021 |
| Final reporting                  | October 2021         |